

Art Critic Impressed by Work Of Sieven at Taylor Galleries

By HELEN W. HENDERSON

Ed. Note: Miss Henderson is a distinguished art critic, well known here and abroad. She was for several years art critic of the Philadelphia Inquirer and did many special articles for that newspaper in the foreign field. While abroad, Miss Henderson resided in Paris, France. She loves France hopes someday to return to Paris. She is the author of a series of books, "Loiter In New York," "Loiter in New England," "Loiter In Paris," and "Loiter In London." Her "Dian de Poitiers" and "Cathedrals of France" won her the decoration, "Officer of the French Academy" by the French Ministry of Public Instruction. Miss Henderson has visited Nantucket several times. At the editor's request, she kindly consented to interrupt her holiday here and write the following critique on the current Kenneth Taylor Galleries exhibit—one of several this season.

For the third time the Art Collectors and Artists Association are offering to Nantucketers an opportunity to see an exhibition of a certain well-known side of the art movement in New York at the present time. The exhibition is held in the Kenneth Taylor Galleries on the Straight Wharf. It opened last Monday evening with a Private View, attended by between one hundred and fifty to two hundred persons and will be open afternoons for three weeks.

The exhibition is sponsored by the Nantucket Foundation Inc. which was formed by a small group of people interested in raising the standard of art collections in their community. George T. Hamilton is director of the gallery which is lodged in a fine substantial old brick building, whose original purpose was a storage warehouse for sperm oil. It is very much in its original condition with the exception of a strong cement floor. The walls and ceilings have been treated in neutral colors and altogether one could scarcely imagine a more suitable place for holding such exhibitions.

The artist advisers who selected the exhibits are: Alexander Brook, Edwin W. Dickenson, Carl Miller, John Sloan, Eugene Speicher, Henry Lee McFee, and Sigmund Menten.

To speak of a few individual exhibits for the show is uneven in character and quality, a prolonged inspection must invariably single out John Sloan's important canvas entitled "Jewel in Red," a very solid painting, done in a interesting mannerism which may or may not appeal to the laity, but which is bound to interest those concerned with painting in the abstract. The girl is not beautiful, but the flesh is firm and round and the color scheme handsome. Sloan, who is an old New York painter, began his career many years ago in Philadelphia studying at the Pennsylvania Academy of the Fine Arts, later becoming a disciple of Robert Henri. His work, however, has gone far beyond those early influences and is admirable in its originality and power.

The work of Sigmund Menkes is attractive in quite another vein. His "Field Flowers," a rough study of rather ugly flowers has no beauty but shows a very serious attitude towards art and will reward prolonged contemplation. The canvas has symmetry rhythm, balance, and all those qualities which make a picture "grow upon one" as the phrase is. "Bitter Sweet," by the same artist is coarse as to technique but interesting in design and power.

Franz Lerch, whose "Young Couple" won the State Prize in Vienna, has decided decorative quality and his picture is done with taste and expression. His "Woman in Red Gloves" is less pleasing.

Eugene Speicher's "Spring Bouquet" is disappointing, for Speicher is an excellent painter. His study of narcissus, lilacs, lilies, rhododendrons compares unfavorably with Mr. Menkes' flower studies, being a rather heavy handed delineation of the obvious.

I should like to say a word for Maurice Sieven who is represented by two romantic, poetic landscapes — "Suburbia" and "Fire Island." These pictures have charm and a real sense of beauty, which sets them apart from the rest of the exhibition. This man has a touch of the sacred fire.

